

The role of people vs. documents in revitalisation

How can revitalisation practitioners
use language documentation?

Aldo Berríos Castillo (UoE)

Objectives

1. Define what linguistic legacy materials* are and explain their role in language revitalisation.
2. Identify key challenges in adapting legacy materials for contemporary use.
3. Compare how legacy materials are adapted in different sociolinguistic contexts:
 - a. South America - Mapudungun
 - b. Mesoamerica - Classical Zapotec



394

Ru

Rutretun pellizcar
Rüñan=*rəñan*
Rüñen, *shüñen* ser grueso
Rüñkūn n. saltar
Rütran=*rətran*

S

Serfin n. y tr. 1.ª servir; *serfiñ* sirviente
Setrulen estar apoyado; *setrukəñun* tr. 1.ª dar apoyo
Suran n. jurar

Sh

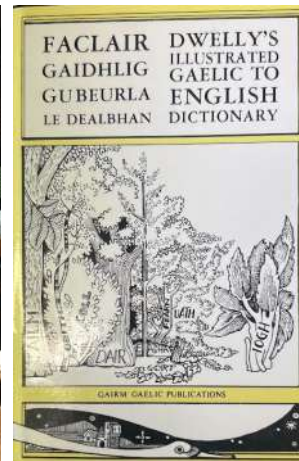
Shakin tr. 1.ª honrar
Shechu=*setru*
Sholkin tr. 1.ª arrancar el cutis
Shuchetun descabezar (trigo, cebada)
Shumpatun tr. 1.ª atentar
Shüñen=*rüñen* ser grueso
Shüñen n. correrse (sólo usado en sus compuestos: *shüñeru-*



* we will focus on written legacy materials

Layout

1. What are legacy materials?
2. Challenges in using legacy materials
3. Cases
 - a. “Colonial Valley Zapotec (Mesoamerica)”
 - b. “Mapudungun (South America)”
4. Wrap up and key takeaways
5. Writing prompt exercise



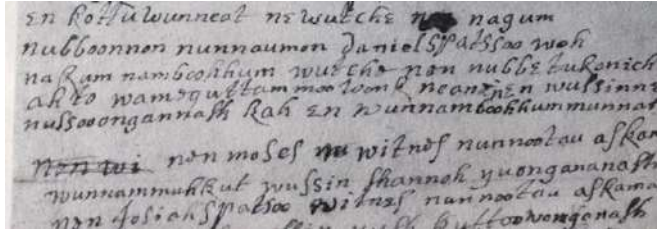
Legacy Written Materials

Historical linguistic resources inherited from previous generations.

They include:

- Historical records
- Missionary works
- Early research
- Digital heritage

The Wôpanâak Language Reclamation Project (WLRP) uses Wôpanâak translations of the Bible (mid1600s) as well as other materials.



1. Practical and technical challenges

Physical Deterioration: Fragile materials, decaying paper, brittle analog tapes.

Obsolete Formats: Old audio formats, and older digital files may be unreadable by modern software.

Sparse Metadata: Historical materials often lack crucial "metadata" (contextual information), such as who the speakers were, when and where the recording was made, or the specific goals of the original collector.



Austin (2021)

Image source: <https://www.neh.gov/article/finding-words>

2. Form and content Issues

Analytical Frameworks: Unfamiliar terminology, outdated grammatical systems, obscure typographies.

Incomplete Data: Too specific genres like religious texts or formal narratives, lack of everyday language, lullabies, or children's speech

Inaccuracies: Older records may over-distinguish or under-distinguish crucial sounds or use “idealized” versions of the language that “clean up” how people actually spoke. “Focus on the past”

The Yagun Phonetic Alphabet.

The letter	is always	The letter	is always	The letter	is always		
written	printed	written	printed	written	printed		
A a	A a	a in at	O o	O o	oa in out		
H h	H h	a - almost	L s	L s	sa - far		
Θ θ	Θ θ	a - all.	Consonants.		Z z	z - is	
O o	O o	o - olive	C c	C c	e in cot	S s	s in so
W w	W w	oo - foot	G g	G g	g - go	Σ s	sh - show
U u	U u	oo - food	T t	T t	t - to	Σ z	s - please
I i	I i	i - ill	D d	D d	d - do	L l	l - low
E e	E e	ee - eat	P p	P p	p - put	L l	ll - milk
E e	E e	i - ill	B b	B b	b - bat	M m	M m
A a	A a	ai - aim	F f	F f	f - foe	N n	N n
I i	I i	i - idle	V v	V v	v - vase	N n	nn - almost
O o	O o	oi - oil	C c	C c	ck - chin	Y y	Y y
U u	U u	u - ud	J j	J j	j - jade	R r	R r
S s	S s	ow - owl	T t	T t	th - thin	R r	rr - round
						K k	ch - German

Beside the above letters there are three vowel marks, ' = h, ' = y, ' = w only found over vowels, hence their name. These marks are often found united over vowels, thus uā = uahwa sij. ahiā = wahya sij. a door; ūā = uuhwa sij. hinder of birds' down. The effect of these marks always precedes the vowels over which they are found.

Yagan texts

written by Bridges in the 19th Century.

They do not have Unicode equivalents.

(Ben Molineaux)

Source: <https://benmolineaux.ppls.ed.ac.uk>

3. Ethical and political Issues

Rights and Access: Unclear intellectual property rights (original researcher, institution, descendant community?)

Sensitive Content: Sacred, taboo, or personal information no longer appropriate to share publicly according to contemporary community standards.

Community Mismatch: The modern community's identity or membership may not align perfectly with the group documented in the historical records, leading to disputes over "ownership" of the data.

Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander readers are advised that the following video contains the images, voices and names of people who have died.

Dr M Yunupingu's full name, voice and image are used with permission from his family.



WARNING: Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander readers are advised that this story contains the names and images of people who have died, used with the permission of their family.

A Queensland community is mourning a mother, son and his best friend who were allegedly murdered in an arson attack.

Jordana Johnson, 36, her son Jordan Norris, 13 — both Goreng Goreng and South Sea Islander — and his friend Chazz Mather, 12, died in the Gladstone house fire on October 15.

Let's identify challenges when working with legacy materials in the following excerpt by Michael Bauer, the language practitioner behind Faclair.com

- 1 Practical and technical issues
- 2 Form and content issues
- 3 Ethical and political issues



”

I started working on turning Dwelly's [Old Gaelic Dictionary] into a digital file [...] when I grew fed up with the lack of English to Gaelic dictionaries [...] After having tried the "type it into the computer" approach for a while (I got to the letter B) I abandoned that approach in favour of a human existence and began using OCR (Optical Character Recognition) on scanned pages of the dictionary. But although the technology had improved somewhat by then, that was by far the easiest bit, resulting in something called "brochan" [mess] in technical language. Proofreading it then was the long and drawn out affair as life kept interfering with mundane issues.

Once that was done, copyright issues and my lack of computing skills put everything on ice until William (who is much better at programming than I am!) contacted me one day not so long ago. He had also got permission to put the dictionary online, so in the twinkling of an eye, suddenly there we were.

So 10 years after getting started, I'm now delighted to see Dwelly-d being now available to a much wider audience. Put it to good use and enjoy!

Michael "Akerbeltz" Bauer

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Technical issues:
digitalisation

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Ethical and political issues:
ownership

Michael "Akerbeltz" Bauer

Working with legacy materials

2 cases of written legacy material adaptations

Mapudungun Nemülkawe - Mapuche (Chile & Argentina)

Mapudungun - Spanish dictionary with audio and educational materials, developed by a grass-root organisation (Fiwfiw) and academics.



Ticha Project - Zapotec (Mesoamerica)

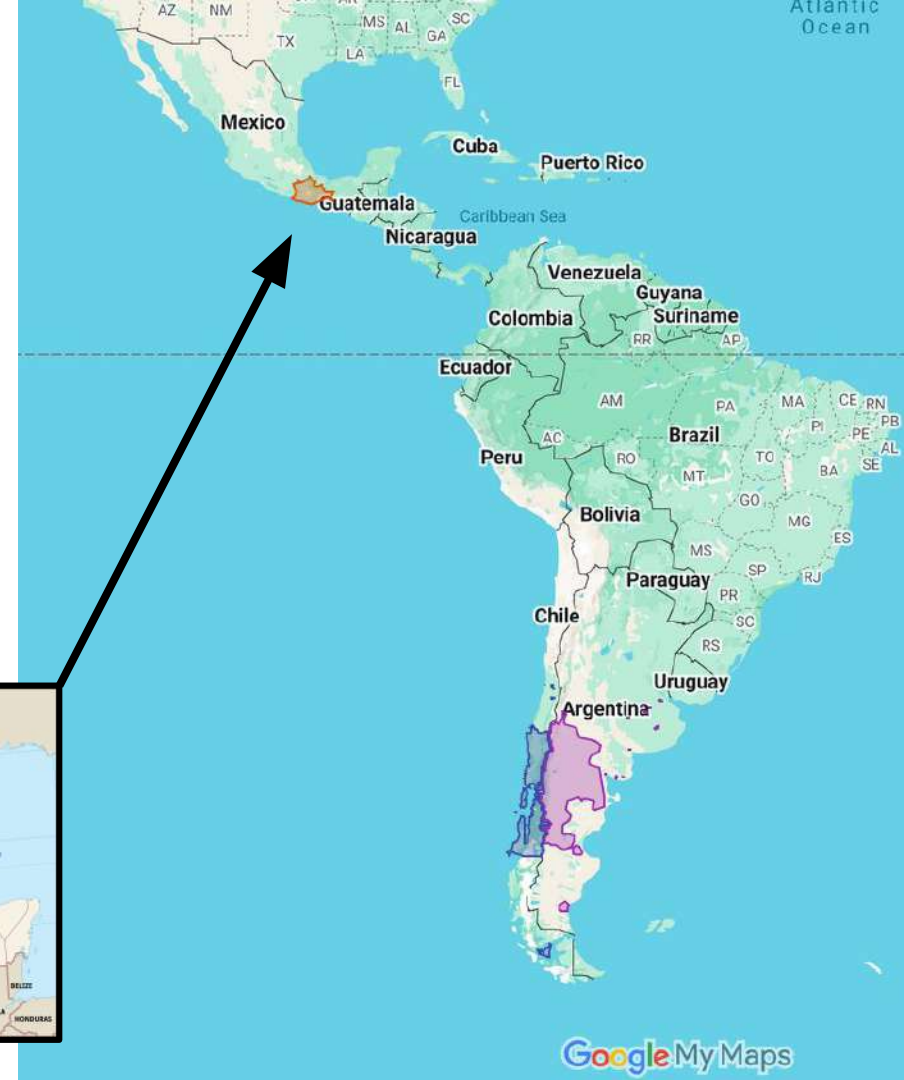
Digital text explorer with access to images, transcriptions, analysis and translations of the Colonial Zapotec texts.



Ticha Project

Ticha project: A digital Text Explorer

- Zapotec language family with more than 50 languages (Oaxaca, Mexico)
- Longest record of alphabetic writing in the Americas (earliest 1565)



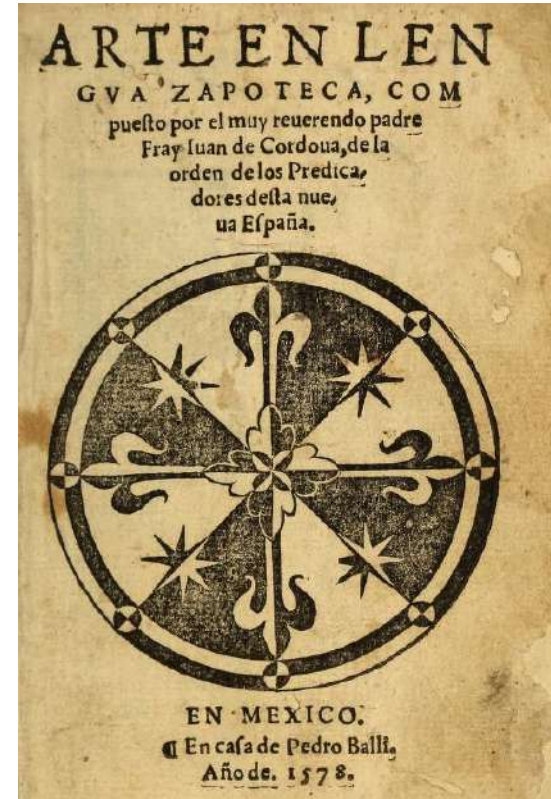
Ticha Project

Digital text explorer with access to images, transcriptions, analysis and translations of the Colonial Zapotec texts.

Linguistic resources: Grammar and dictionaries

Religious documents: Doctrines

Administrative documents: Wills and testaments

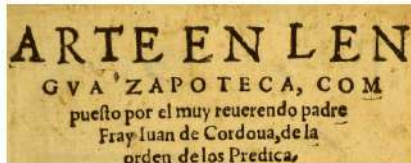


Challenges of the colonial materials

- Lack of physical access to archives (housed in various place in Mexico, USA, and Europe) and sometimes not stored in the best condition
- Institutional discrimination against indigenous communities
- Incomplete metadata
- Opaque writing and printing conventions for colonial documents and inconsistent orthographies and written material needs training for being read
- Language change over the last 500 years
- Permission is needed to share the documents.

ARTE EN LENGUA ZAPOTECA

el libro primero gramática de Colima y el segundo de Juan de Cordova



ABOUT THE ARTE EN LENGUA ZAPOTECA

The Arte is a grammar of Colonial Valley Zapotec published in 1578. It is the first grammar of Zapotec to be published. It was written by Fray Juan de Cordova, a Spanish priest in the Dominican order, although, like other Spanish clergy working with indigenous languages, Cordova relied on the help of native speakers of Zapotec. Unfortunately, little is known about these helpers, which means that we do not know precisely what variety of Zapotec the Arte records. Cordova wrote the Arte like a Latin grammar, making it difficult for modern readers to understand the structure of the text. To better to illustrate the content of the text, modern readings are given alongside Cordova's original native ideas. Despite the lack of technology, it is still an important source for knowledge about Colonial Valley Zapotec.

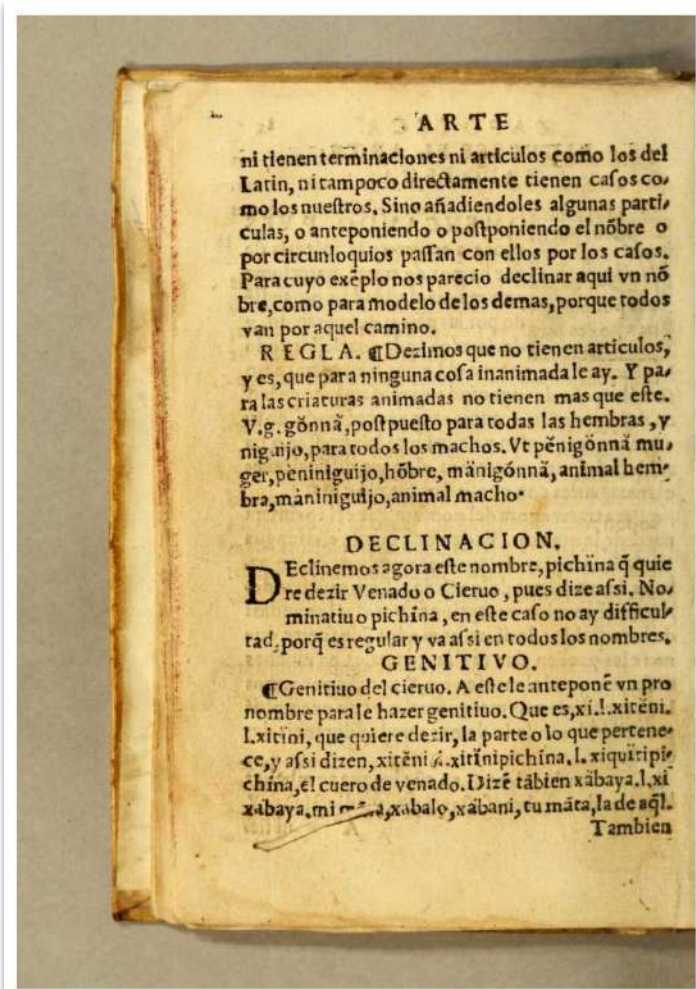
ARTE OUTLINE

See how Fray Juan de Cordova organized his 16th century grammar of Colonial Valley Zapotec.

ORIGINAL TRANSCRIPTION

Look at a full transcription of the Arte.





TranscriptionModern Spanish

ARTE

ni tienen terminaciones ni artículos como los del Latin, ni tampoco directamente tienen casos como los nuestros. Sino añadiendoles algunas partículas, o anteponiendo o postponiendo el nōbre o por circunloquios passan con ellos por los casos. Para cuyo exēplo nos parecio declinar aqui vn nōbre, como para modelo de los demas, porque todos van por aquel camino.

REGLA. ¶ Dezimos que no tienen artículos, y es, que para ninguna cosa inanimada le ay. Y para las criaturas animadas no tienen mas que este. V.g. gönnā, postpuesto para todas las hembras, y niguijo, para todos los machos. Vt pēnigönnā mu- ger, pēniniguijo, hōbre, mānigönnā, animal he- bra, māniniguijo, animal macho.

DECLINACION.

Declinemos agora este nombre, pichina q̄ quie- re dezir Venado o Cieruo, pues dize así. No- minatiuo pichina, en este caso no ay difficul- tad, porq̄ es regular y va así en todos los nombres.

GENITIVO.

¶ Genitiuo del cieruo. A este le antepone vn pro- nombre para le hazer genitiuo. Que es, xi. l. xitēni. l. xitini, que quiere dezir, la parte o lo que pertene- ce, y así dizen, xitēni l. xitēnipichina. l. xiquitipi- china, el cuero de venado. Dizē también xābaya. l. xi xābaya, mi cō- a, xābalo, xābani, tu mātā, la de aq̄l. También

ni tienen terminaciones ni artículos como los del Latin, ni tampoco directamente tienen casos co- mo los nuestros. Sino añadiendoles algunas parti- culas, o anteponiendo o postponiendo el nōbre o por circunloquios passan con ellos por los casos. Para cuyo exēplo nos parecio declinar aqui vn nō bre, como para modelo de los demas, porque todos van por aquel camino.

REGLA. Dezimos que no tienen artículos, y es, que para ninguna cosa inanimada le ay. Y pa- ra las criaturas animadas no tienen mas que este. Verbi gratia gönnā, postpuesto para todas las h- niguijo, para todos los machos. Vt pēnigönnā mu- ger, pēniniguijo, hōbre, mānigönnā, animal he- bra, maniniguijo, animal macho.

DECLINACION.

2.2 Declinación

2.2.1 [Nominativo]

Declinemos a- re dezir Venado o C- minatiuo pichina, tad, porq̄ es regula-

pichina
pichina
deer
'deer'

re, pichina q̄ quie- ze así. No ay difficul- todos los nombres.

GENITIVO.

2.2.2 Genitivo

pēni gönnā
pēni gönnā
person female
'woman'

Pedagogical material

1. Ticha: an Introduction



2. Colonial Documents and Archives



3. Reading an Interlinear Analysis



4. Numbers



5. Language Shift



6. Twitter and Zapotec Language Activism



7. The Written and Intellectual Legacy of the Zapotecs



8. Reclaiming our Languages



Caseidyneën Saën – Learning Together

Colonial Valley Zapotec Teaching Materials

Xóchitl Flores-Marcial, Moisés García Guzmán, Felipe H. Lopez, George Aaron Broadwell, Alejandra Dubcovsky, May Helena Plumb, Mike Zarafonetis, and Brook Danielle Lillehaugen

All Rights Reserved

READ BOOK



Mapuche in Chile

- Most populous Indigenous People in Chile: 1.745.000
- Political exclusion and no constitutional recognition
- Numerous conflicts with extractive projects of natural resources in Mapuche ancestral territories



Movement for Mapudungun

Mapuche organisations that promote language revitalisation through:

- community-based approaches
- linguistic reclamation
- immersion boarding schools during summer and winter holidays, called *koneltun*



Fiw Fiw ñi Dungun 'Speech of Fiw Fiw'

A non-profit organisation that promotes Mapudungun in the Mapuche territory.

Teaching Mapudungun as a Second Language linguistic immersion.

- Courses and workshops
- Online and in-person
- Creation of materials



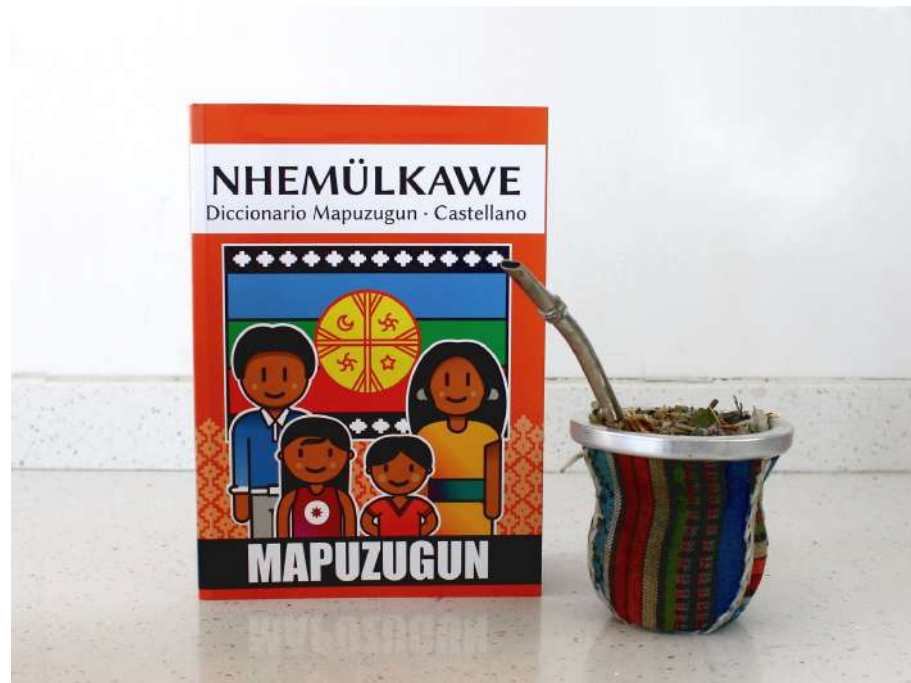
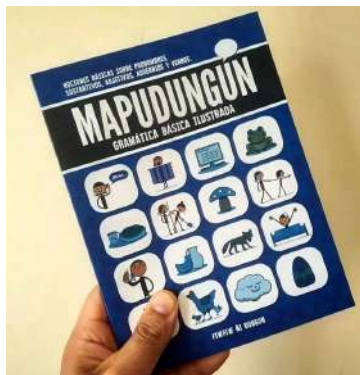
Courses and workshops



Online courses



Summer Immersion camps



We had published teaching materials (a grammar and a dictionary), but did not have an online resource.

Project Overview: Mapudungun Nemülkawe

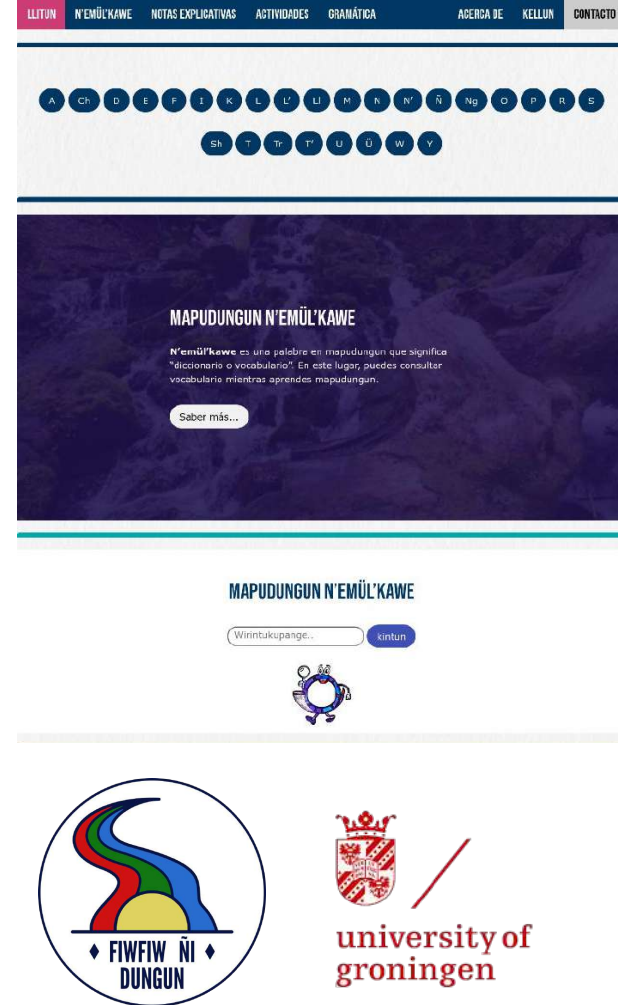
Open-access online Mapudungun dictionary with examples and audio playback (Talking dictionary)

Developed by a language revitalisation organisation:
Fiwfiw

Collaborative work: Native speakers, neo-speakers & activists and researchers (Groningen University)

Timeframe: Sept 2024 – Apr 2025

www.mapudungun.cl

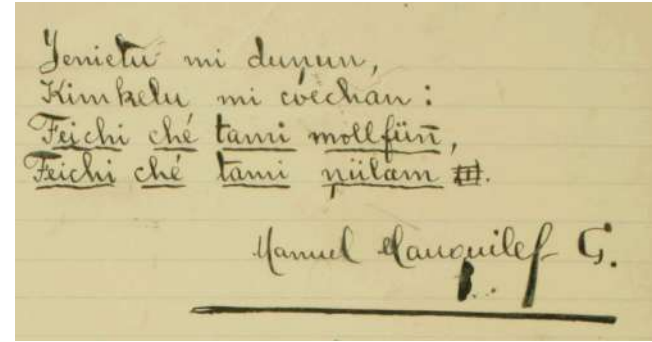


Why This Project?

Accessible lexical resources for learners, who most have access to internet and a cellphone.

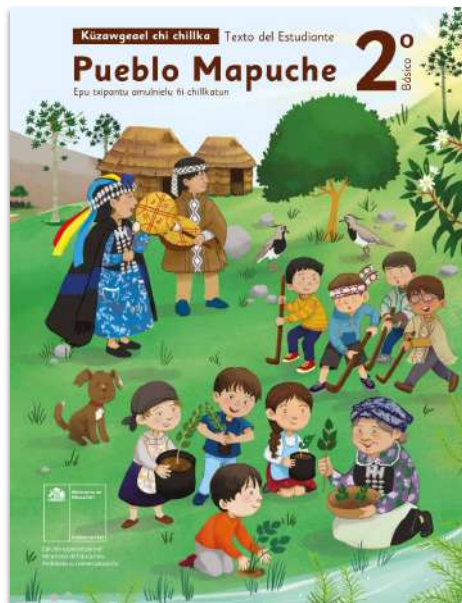
Existing materials were fragmented (wordlists, glossaries) and not systematically organised.

Goal: move toward a structured, searchable lexicographic resource with playable audio and real examples

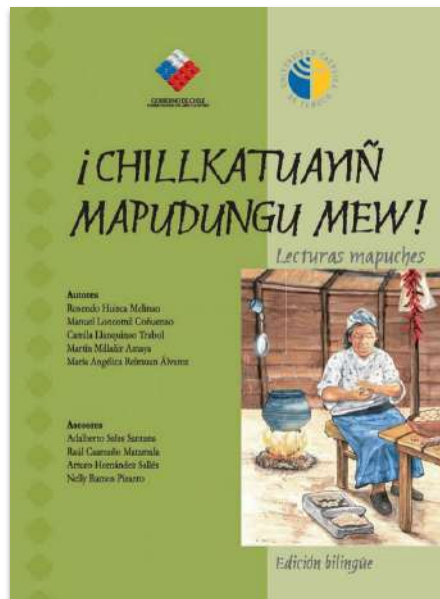


From Legacy Materials to a New Resource

Two textbooks 2022



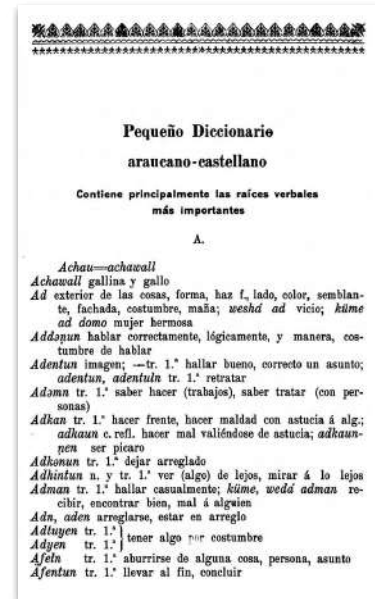
Short stories 1980s (reimp. 2007)



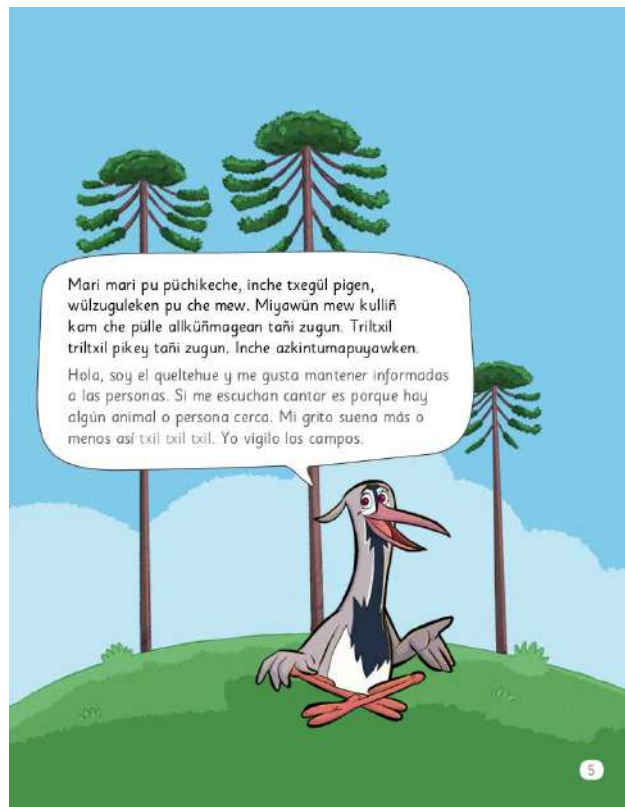
Pedagogical texts for literacy, 1987



Glossary 1900s



First, we identified lexical units and their contexts



adkintumapun
allkün
che
dungun
dungun
inche
kam
kulliñ
mew
miyawün

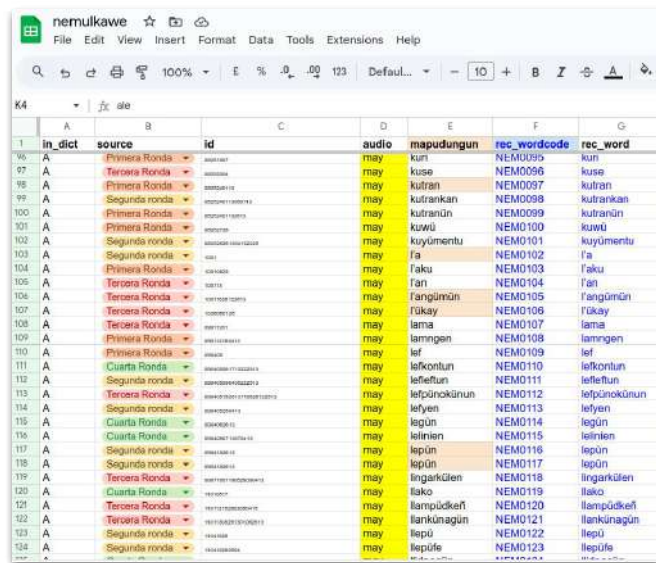
pin
pingen
pu
püchikeche
pülle
tañi
tregül
triltil triltil
wüldungun

This information was collected into a shared spreadsheet

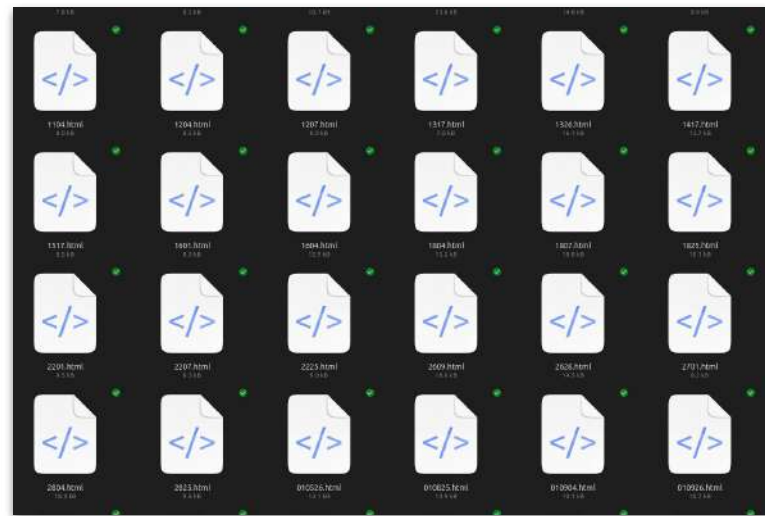
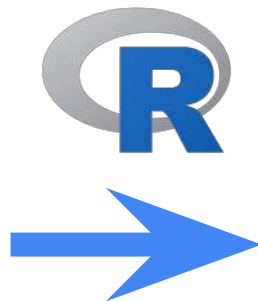
lemma - morphological analysis - stem - class - Spanish - example - source

	A	B	C	D	E	F	G	H	I
1	id	mapudungun	segmentacion	base	clase	español	ejemplo	audio	origen
2	010526122613	afümün	afül-m]-ün	afü	verbo	cocinar algo	<dl><dt>Ejemplo en mapudun		FFD 2024
3	01052613	afün	afül-n	afü	verbo	cocinarse, coc	<dl><dt>Ejemplo en mapudun		FFD 2028
4	010526	afü	afü	afü	radical	radical de afün	<dl><dt>Ejemplo en mapudun		FFD 2028
5	01090801	alka	alka	alka	sustantivo	gallo	<dl><dt>Ejemplo en mapudun		FFD 2023
6	01090801	alka	alka	alka	adjetivo	macho	<dl><dt>Ejemplo en mapudun		FFD 2024
7	011225	amu	amu	amu	radical	Raíz de amun.	<dl><dt>Ejemplo en mapudun		FFD 2044
8	01122513	amun	amu]-n	amu	verbo	ir, andar	<dl><dt>Ejemplo en mapudun		FFD 2044
9	011225222513	amutun	amu]-tu]-n	amu	verbo	irse, volverse a	<dl><dt>Ejemplo en mapudun		FFD 2043
10	012826	ayü	ayü	ayü	radical	Raíz de ayün.	<dl><dt>Ejemplo en mapudun		FFD 2044
11	012826050109	ayüfal	ayül]-fal	ayü	sustantivo	querible	<dl><dt></dt><dd></dd></dl>		Augusta 190
12	01282613	ayün	ayül]-n	ayü	sustantivo	querer	<dl><dt>Feytichi achawall niey		FFD 2022
13	0204	che	che	che	sustantivo	gente, persona	<dl><dt>Ejemplo en mapudun		FFD 2041
14	080712	kim	kim	kim	adjetivo	sabio, que sabi	<dl><dt>Ejemplo en mapudun		FFD 2036
15	080712040922	kimeltuchefe	kim]-el]-tu]-che]-fe	kim	sustantivo	profesor, perso	<dl><dt>Ejemplo en mapudun		FFD 2035
16	080712040922	kimeltun	kim]-el]-tu]-n	kim	verbo	enseñar a algu	<dl><dt>Ejemplo en mapudun		FFD 2040
17	080712040926	kimelün	kim]-el]-ün	kim	verbo	enseñar, dar a	<dl><dt>Ejemplo en mapudun		FFD 2039
18	0807122613	kimün	kim]-ün	kim	sustantivo	sabiduría, conc	<dl><dt>Ejemplo en mapudun		FFD 2037
19	0807122613	kimün	kim]-ün	kim	verbo	saber, conocer	<dl><dt>Ejemplo en mapudun		FFD 2038
20	0826030127	küdaw	küdaw	küdaw	sustantivo	trabajo	<dl><dt>Ejemplo en mapudun		FFD 2030
21	082603012705	küdawfe	küdaw]-fe	küdaw	sustantivo	trabajador	<dl><dt>Ejemplo en mapudun		FFD 2029
22	082603012726	küdawün	küdaw]-ün	küdaw	verbo	trabajar	<dl><dt>Ejemplo en mapudun		FFD 2031
23	082603012727	küdawwe	küdaw]-we	küdaw	sustantivo	lugar de trabaj	<dl><dt>Ejemplo en mapudun		FFD 2032

From the spreadsheet to HTML files (website), using an R script



1	A	B	C	D	E	F	G
	in_dict	source	id	audio	mapudungun	rec_wordcode	rec_word
96	A	Primera Ronda	00000001	may	kuti	NEM0095	kuti
97	A	Tercera Ronda	00000002	may	kuse	NEM0096	kuse
98	A	Primera Ronda	00000003	may	kutran	NEM0097	kutran
99	A	Segunda Ronda	00000004	may	kutrankan	NEM0098	kutrankan
100	A	Primera Ronda	00000005	may	kutranin	NEM0099	kutranin
101	A	Primera Ronda	00000006	may	kuwu	NEM0100	kuwu
102	A	Segunda Ronda	00000007	may	kuyimuntu	NEM0101	kuyimuntu
103	A	Segunda Ronda	00000008	may	fa	NEM0102	fa
104	A	Primera Ronda	00000009	may	faku	NEM0103	faku
105	A	Tercera Ronda	00000010	may	fari	NEM0104	fari
106	A	Tercera Ronda	00000011	may	fangumün	NEM0105	fangumün
107	A	Tercera Ronda	00000012	may	fukay	NEM0106	fukay
108	A	Tercera Ronda	00000013	may	lama	NEM0107	lama
109	A	Primera Ronda	00000014	may	lamngen	NEM0108	lamngen
110	A	Primera Ronda	00000015	may	lef	NEM0109	lef
111	A	Cuarta Ronda	00000016	may	lefkontun	NEM0110	lefkontun
112	A	Segunda Ronda	00000017	may	lefteftun	NEM0111	lefteftun
113	A	Tercera Ronda	00000018	may	lefpuñokünun	NEM0112	lefpuñokünun
114	A	Segunda Ronda	00000019	may	lefyan	NEM0113	lefyan
115	A	Cuarta Ronda	00000020	may	legün	NEM0114	legün
116	A	Cuarta Ronda	00000021	may	lelinien	NEM0115	lelinien
117	A	Segunda Ronda	00000022	may	lepün	NEM0116	lepün
118	A	Segunda Ronda	00000023	may	lepün	NEM0117	lepün
119	A	Tercera Ronda	00000024	may	lingarkülen	NEM0118	lingarkülen
120	A	Cuarta Ronda	00000025	may	llako	NEM0119	llako
121	A	Tercera Ronda	00000026	may	llampüdeñ	NEM0120	llampüdeñ
122	A	Tercera Ronda	00000027	may	llankünagün	NEM0121	llankünagün
123	A	Segunda Ronda	00000028	may	llepü	NEM0122	llepü
124	A	Segunda Ronda	00000029	may	llepüfe	NEM0123	llepüfe



The files are hosted in a repository and posted using GitHub pages.



From dictionary to educational tool

Platform includes:

Dictionary (translations, examples, audio)

Explanatory notes (grammar & morphology)

But also:

Pedagogical materials

Classroom activities

B. RUKA KUDAW

Chilikatunge tufachi epen.

EPU WENTRU

Kife kido wentru pepi trakakerelay, fey kongelu wentru trawmangy. Pilerkelay fi chuchi pole fi amual. feyen mew engu numefina wefangikoyngu.

- Chumafuyu chey anay wenio? muna weda feleyu. pepi kodawlayu tayu feyen mew- piwörkeyngu fi nitramkawün engu.

welu kife antü rakiduamnumey fi wewafel ta pilata engu. Fey chi lüdi wentru rakiduamnumey fi chumgechi fi tripayafel fi kontukudawael, fey pikzeyti fi wenioy:

-Eymi mefkuan, inche feyprincaeyu tamr chew pole kanuael - pikiet chi trawma fey tripayngu .

Kife silmen wentru elueyew ködew, pefukamafalu engu, mefkuyawöngely tati lüdi wentru, kisu am pelokulu, kawulu reko miyawöfifi ti trawma, fi noytupafuael , femngechi tati wewafel pilata engu.

(Chilikä tural: Rawesael, Juan. Kife wentru ka kife trapaal. 1993.)

Foli	Chen	foli + chen	Künal wirin
		Katöketran	Wiya amuan nuka fi fuka möley kaffin mew. Feychi pilä katöketrayan.
			
Katü-			
			

II. CATEGORÍAS LÉXICAS

2.1 SUSTANTIVOS

Representación en el diccionario: **sustantivos**

Los **sustantivos** corresponden a la clase de palabras que refieren a personas, animales u objetos; y que, por lo general, tienden a cumplir la función de un argumento, aunque es posible que en ciertas construcciones puedan funcionar como predicados (Shopen, 2007). En mapudungun, los sustantivos en términos morfológicos se presentan invariables; es decir, no bienen flexión de caso, número o género.

Por medio de un sistema productivo de morfología derivativa, se pueden crear nuevos sustantivos. Algunos de los sufijos nominales son **-fe**, **-we**, **-etü**, **-wen**, **-n**. Veamos a continuación algunos ejemplos de uso de estos sufijos.

(1) **ketu** + **-fe** > **ketufe**

En el ejemplo (1), la palabra **ketu** es una raíz o base que significa "ayudar". Por otro lado, el sufijo **-fe** cuando se une a una base significa que una persona realiza o va a realizar la acción que expresa ese verbo. El sustantivo derivado de esta manera, **ketufe** a partir de la raíz **ketu** y el sufijo **-fe** de agente significa "quien ayuda o ayudará".

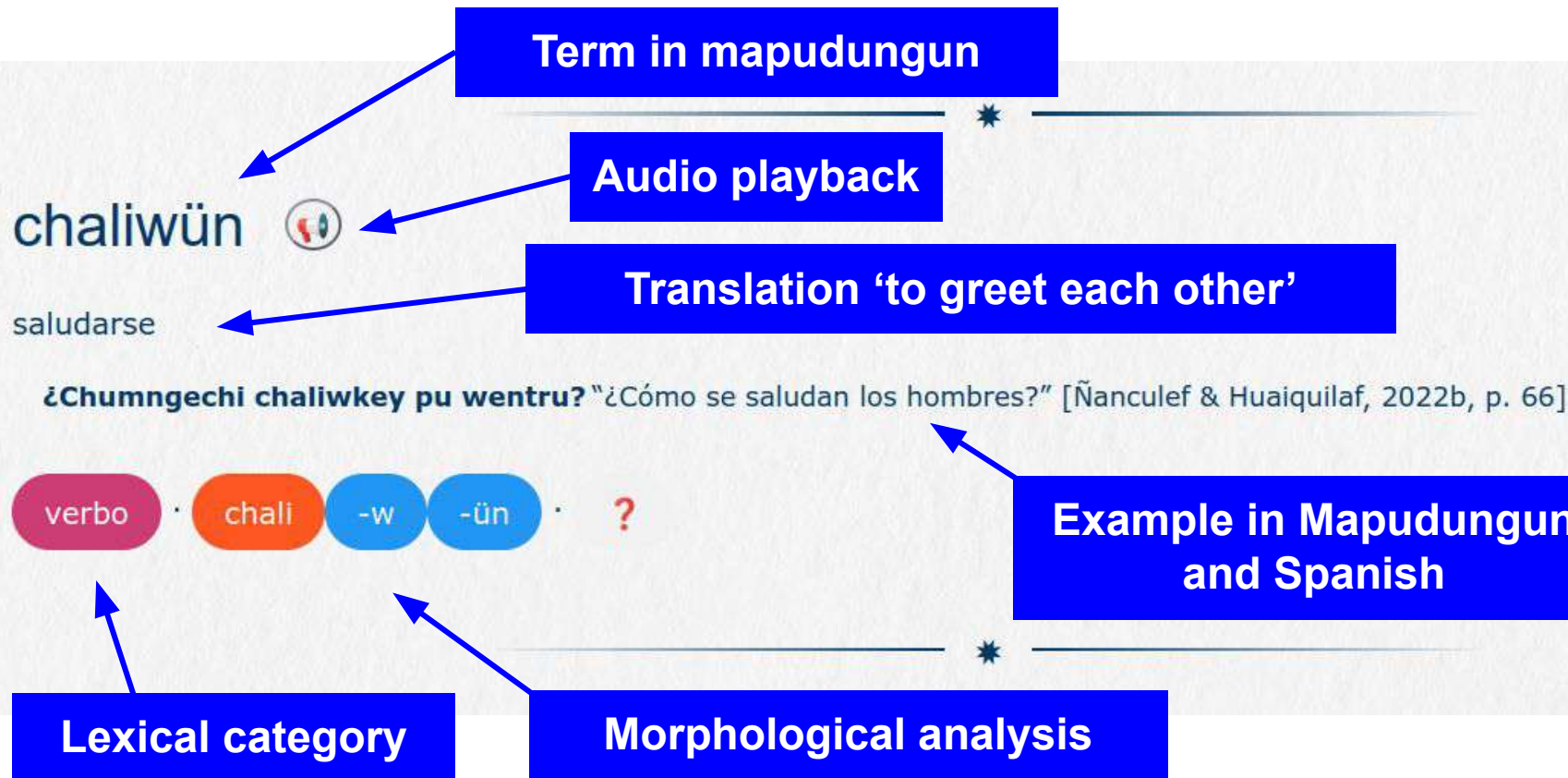
(2) **kupit** + **-we** > **kupitwe**

En el ejemplo (2), de **kupit** "raíz de fajar (paquetar)" + **-we**, el "sufijo de instrumento", se deriva la palabra **kupitwe**, que significa "bata transportable". El sufijo **-we** también puede derivar sustantivos que significa lugar donde se realiza una acción. Por ejemplo, la palabra **chilikatunwe** se traduce en castellano como "censuero, colegio", puedes adivinar qué significa **chilikatun**, entonces?

(3) **kut** + **-n** > **kutn**

En el ejemplo (3), de la raíz **kut** "tratar" + **-n**, el "sufijo de objeto", deriva la palabra **kutn** "medicamento".

Anatomy of an entry



Some challenges during the project

- Different orthographies in the materials
 - /ŋ/ was represented as “ng” or “g”; /i/ as “ü” or “v”
 ‘fox’ *ngürü ~ gürü ~ gvrv*
- Sacred terms used in some texts (not shown here)
 - **Filew** “the name used by the *püjü* [spirits] to refer to a *machi* [shaman]. Humans say “machi,” while the *püjü* [spirits] say “filew.” Own translation. (Catriquir, 2018)
- Outdated terminology in the oldest glossary
 - kuralnge ‘eye’ (Augusta, 1903) vs. nge ‘eye’ (nowadays)

Key Insights for Revitalisation

Legacy materials are not static archives, but resources for transformation.

Effective revitalisation tools combine:

- Legacy data
- Linguistic analysis
- Community knowledge
- Digital technology

Result: Legacy materials become usable resources for learners and tools for language recovery

“Linguistic legacy materials are more than containers for data, they are the basis for reconciling generations of academic practices and language users”
(Weber, 2023).

Fentepuy

Writing Prompt

Suppose you are working with written legacy materials to create a glossary for online dissemination. (a) Recent community protocols prohibit the public display of sacred vocabulary, and (b) some terms in the materials differ in meaning from their contemporary usage within the speech community.

1. How would you address these issues when selecting, organising, and presenting lexical items? Provide separate answers for (a) and (b).
2. How might different groups of users receive and respond to your decisions over time, particularly in relation to accessibility and perceived authenticity?